

A hand with a finger pointing upwards towards a shopping cart icon. The cart icon is inside a circular graphic with a downward arrow. Several 'SALE' labels in circular frames are scattered around the background.

Set up Your Own E-Commerce Platform with Spree

Quite often, businesses want niche software solutions but don't have the hours, expertise or capital to invest in them. However, often, such solutions already exist in the open source world. Spree is an example of such a pre-baked e-commerce platform built with Ruby on Rails. It lets you set up your own Web store within minutes, and truly justifies the 'Don't reinvent the wheel' mantra.

An e-commerce store should be highly customised in its look, feel and workflow to match the requirements of the seller. It should showcase all the products elegantly, provide a catalogue of available items, allow users to search through the myriad products, and offer administrators the controls to monitor all aspects of user behaviour. Spree has tons of features that satisfy these core requirements, along with much more functionality. Here is a quick peek at what it has to offer.

Easy customisability

The power of Spree lies in the extent to which it can be customised. It offers such flexibility with application-specific customisation, extensions and themes. Let's look at all three aspects. The official Spree docs explain 'application-specific' customisations as "...used by developers and designers to tweak Spree's behaviour or appearance to match a particular business' operating procedures or branding, or to provide a unique feature." These are the most basic sets of customisations a store needs.

Extensions add logic and functionality to Spree. Themes, on the other hand, just change the look and feel of the store. Both extensions and themes are usually distributed as Ruby packages called 'gems'.

Moreover, Spree gives us the flexibility to choose a 'Checkout flow' for the items. You can have a single-step or multiple-step checkout, with standard or AJAX navigation. Also, adding

discounts, taxes and other rules to the process is totally effortless.

Powerful administrative controls

Managing your products and orders is a breeze with Spree. You can have multiple variations of items based on colour and size. Custom properties can be added to products. It is also easy to control all aspects of your order life cycle. Inventory-tracking features help you track each and every product, with detailed analytics provided to help understand buyers' actions.

Integration with payment gateways and shipping carriers

Payment gateways allow secure payment transactions. In addition to the default gateways supported out-of-the-box, with Spree GatewayGem you can integrate with several popular payment services. For shipping items, the customer gets to see all the available providers, with their costs for that particular zone, prior to choosing one. The shipping costs finally get added to the product cost.

Easy SSL and SEO

The official Spree guide makes it easy to set up a search-engine-friendly Web store that supports SSL.

REST API

Spree provides a convenient API to access store data. With